

Incubation Project

We are two ESMT Berlin students participating in an entrepreneurship program. We are reaching out to experienced business owners and professionals.

Where we come from. Wolf worked in his family's steel manufacturing business for over two years, understanding the importance of processes that were never explicitly documented. Giuseppe comes from banking, where financing and acquiring these companies meant confronting the same opacity from the outside.

What we see. Across Europe, organically grown businesses are running on expertise that exists in the heads of their founders and most experienced people. This expertise, the context behind decisions, the culture of how things are done, the judgment that comes from decades of work, was never documented, but the people who hold it won't be there forever. And when they step back, much of what made the business work risks walking out the door with them.

What the evidence has shown us. We have spoken with over 20 founders, successors, M&A professionals, and investors across three countries. A few things keep coming back:

1. Founders who built their companies over 20, 30, 40 years can make decisions almost by instinct. Those who follow them need years to reach the same level
2. When a business is sold, the less documented it is, the lower the price
3. Experienced employees who could carry the business forward often hesitate, not because they lack skill, but because they lack the confidence to make decisions the way the founder did
4. Roughly 80% of established businesses do not manage a successful transition

Based on this, we are building a service that sits alongside the experienced people inside an SME, through conversation, observation, and modern tools, to capture what was never written down: the context, the culture, and the decision logic that makes the business work. The goal is to turn this into a structured asset the company can use, for delegation today, for smoother transitions tomorrow, and for stronger valuation when the time comes.

What we need is your experience. We are not selling anything. We are listening. If anything above resonates, or sounds wrong, that reaction is exactly what we want to hear. 30 minutes of your time and your honest perspective would help us enormously.

Wolf & Giuseppe